

ANI

sembly polls slated in October-November, the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) chief is playing a far bigger game.

Chirag's history with Nitish is one of both rivalry and alliance. In 2020, the then undivided LJP fielded candidates in 135 of Bihar's 243 constituencies, most of them against the JD(U) or Janata Dal (United). This delivered a stinging blow, relegating Nitish's party to third place. Yet, the latest attack is less about enacting an encore than about seizing the present moment.

The BJP, despite being the largest party in the state assembly, with 80 MLAs, lacks a local leader with pan-state appeal who can command loyalty. Conversely, Nitish—once lauded as the architect of Bihar's post-2005 resurgence—now appears diminished. Whispers about his health and his grip on power slipping have spurred speculation of an impending leadership vacuum. In this liminal space, Chirag discerns a fault line ripe for exploitation.

THE ELECTORAL PARADOX

Chirag carries both the promise and the weight of his late father Ram Vilas Paswan's legacy. His ambitions to return to Bihar power politics extend beyond undermining a rival; they also expose a certain existential dilemma: the party has been extraordinary in parliamentary elections—sweeping five out of five seats in 2024, six out of six in 2019 and six out of seven in 2014 on vote shares of just 6-8 per cent—yet it has been a disaster in assembly polls, scoring 3, 2 and 1 seat in the past three elections, respectively.

This is not a statistical anomaly, but a deeper organisational failure: while the party has piggybacked on the larger NDA vote in Lok Sabha contests, it lacks the grassroots machinery, local leadership and policy platform necessary to convert that momentum into state-level power. Compounding this is the widespread perception—dating back to Ram Vilas's tenure as Union minister—that the LJP's interests lie chiefly in central politics, a stand that has led supporters to look elsewhere in assembly elections.

For Chirag, this anomaly is both a challenge and an opportunity. His crusade for a more prominent role in Bihar's politics—evident in his '*Bihar Bula Raha Hai* (Bihar is calling)' campaign, and his party's bold decision to field him from an unreserved seat in the upcoming election—is designed to bridge the gap between national visibility and regional credibility. The hope is that it will transform the LJP from a sporadic spoiler into a decisive force in Patna's corridors of power.

Election fever has yet to pick up in Bihar, but insiders are already whispering about how Chirag's ambitions extend beyond his ministerial berth in New Delhi. One confidant quipped, "Do you think he will come to Patna merely to serve as a minister here? No; the only office that interests him is the chief minister's chair."

LANGUAGE OF THE YOUTH

Although the BJP commands substantial strength elsewhere in the Hindi heartland, Bihar remains the lone state where it has never governed in its own right, perpetually reliant on coalition partners like the JD(U) to secure power. Recognising this, Chirag is now aspiring to occupy the space Nitish has dominated since 2005. An essential part of that will be rejuvenating his LJP faction and whipping up some enthusiasm in the 5.3 per cent Paswan cohort, the largest grouping in the state's 19.7 per cent Scheduled Caste demographic.

Next up is the real possibility that alliance partner BJP will prop him up as a strategic foil to Nitish. Sources say the lack of a leader with pan-state appeal is weighing heavily on the BJP leadership. They have reportedly urged Chirag to campaign across the state, especially in urban and semi-urban pockets where youth voters could tilt the balance. The feeling is that Chirag's 'Bollywood-style charisma', pro-Modi stand and aspirational messaging will resonate across

"CHIRAG SPEAKS THE LANGUAGE OF THE YOUTH. HE'S MODERN, ROOTED AND UNAPOLOGETICALLY AMBITIOUS"

–BJP strategist on LJP leader's role in Bihar poll campaign

"PM MODI AND AMIT SHAH TRUST NITISH KUMAR... EXCESS OF ANYTHING IS BAD, EVERYONE MUST REMEMBER THAT"

NEERAJ KUMAR
JD(U) spokesperson